

# The Hawks Contract

## Private Information for Angel Rocket's Agent

You are Angel Rocket's Agent. Angel is the star center for the Kansas City Tornado, a middle-of-the-pack team in the Women's National Basketball Association (WNBA). It is the 2030 offseason, several years into the era of multi-million-dollar contracts created by the league's landmark 2026 collective bargaining agreement. Angel has been playing for the Tornado for all three years of her professional career. She is presently deliberating on whether to pick up a renewal option to play for the Tornado next year for a flat \$2.1 million salary. Privately, you have advised her that the Tornado, while happy to have her, is unlikely to agree to any re-negotiation of these terms.

One thing you know about your client: she trusts her own judgment. After her rookie season, Angel turned down an early extension that nearly everyone around her — including her representation at the time — urged her to take. She bet on herself, made All-WNBA the next year, and signed the much larger contract now up for renewal. Simply telling Angel that an assessment she believes in is wrong has rarely worked for anyone.

Perhaps because of the publicity surrounding the renewal deliberations, you and Angel received a phone call from the Philadelphia Hawks, a perennial contender. The Hawks present center, Cindy Hooper, is a veteran in the final phase of her career. On the phone, Hawks management put forward the possibility of paying Angel a \$2.5 million salary, saying they would like to sit down and discuss it further. Naturally, Angel was interested in the possibility of playing for a championship team. So you and Angel agreed to a meeting at Hawk's headquarters.

In the meeting with Angel, you noted that, beyond increasing the chances of winning, the Hawks would also benefit from increased merchandizing (Angel Rocket t-shirts, etc.). Angel estimated the chances of winning a championship with the Hawks at 60%. You think she is overly optimistic: the chances are more like 30%. So far, however, you have kept this assessment to yourself. You did say (and believe) that Hawks merchandising profits would be about \$10 million if the Hawks win a championship and \$5 million if they do not win a championship. You both agreed that it would be interesting to hear what the Hawks had to say about these matters.

Your contract with Angel stipulates that you receive 5% of any salary you negotiate on Angel's behalf with the Hawks. You do not share in any merchandising or championship bonus arrangements, nor would you receive any money if Angel stays with the Tornado since this would simply extend the existing contract.

You are mindful that, under the collective bargaining agreement, all compensation to a player must flow through her standard player contract: teams may not compensate players — or their representatives — through side arrangements, and league rules cap the fees agents may collect from clients. Professional basketball has seen high-profile investigations in recent years into

endorsement deals allegedly used to funnel team money to players outside their contracts, and the penalties for circumvention are severe.

The above is private information and is not to be shown to either Angel or Hawks management.

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*This note was prepared as the basis for class discussion rather than to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of an administrative situation. The teams, players, and events depicted are fictional; references to the league's 2026 collective bargaining agreement reflect its publicly reported terms.*

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